

Chapter 18: Data Collection

Running Your Study with Real Participants

Gordon Wright

1 Overview

This chapter supports your data collection session. By this point you have prepared all your documents and practised your procedure — now it's time to run your study for real.

2 Key Points

2.1 Before You Start

1. **Check all materials** — consent forms, instruction sheets, stimulus materials, data recording sheets, debrief forms, pens, timer
2. **Assign roles** — who is experimenter, assistant, and recruiter for each rotation?
3. **Quick rehearsal** — run through the procedure one more time verbally

2.2 During Data Collection

1. **Follow your Researcher Procedure exactly** — read instructions verbatim, keep timing consistent
2. **Stay neutral** — don't react to participant responses, nod encouragingly, or hint at expected answers
3. **Record data immediately** — fill in the Data Recording Sheet after each participant, don't rely on memory
4. **Debrief every participant** — hand them the Debrief Form and answer any questions

2.3 Common Issues

- **Participant asks “What's the right answer?”** — explain there are no right or wrong answers
- **Participant wants to stop** — thank them, remind them they can withdraw, destroy their data
- **Something goes wrong with materials** — note the issue, try to continue, record what happened
- **Timing is off** — complete the session, adjust for the next participant

2.4 After Data Collection

- Count your completed data sheets
- Check for missing entries or unclear handwriting

- Hand all data to Gordon at the end of the session
- Gordon will analyse the data and return your results in Week 20

3 Additional Resources

- Project Toolkit — your complete document reference
- Your Researcher Procedure — follow it step by step